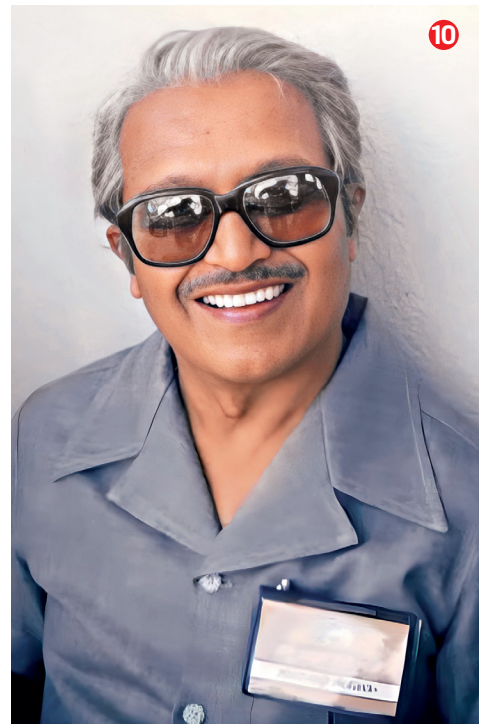
9. Devanoor Mahadeva *(Kannada)*

10. Shantinath Desai *(Kannada)*



BCCL



ate, book comparing Gandhi's idea of Swaraj and the RSS ideology of Hindutva. It required courage and conviction, which he had in plenty.

Girish Karnad, the celebrated playwright, cinema actor, film-maker, too, has been a favourite writer. For one, he understood theatre as a medium as minutely as Satyajit Ray knew cinema as a medium of expression. I have seen his plays in performance in Karnataka, Gujarat and Maharashtra. They were equally effective in all three languages. I met him last when he came to Dharwad for a literary meeting. After that, I met him in Bangalore at a public meeting where he displayed a sign that read, 'I, too, am an urban Naxalite' in defiance of the fear and intimidation being spread. The activist fervour that Ananthamurthy and Karnad displayed was seen in Shivarama Karanth's work. His peers, like D.R. Bendre and K.V. Puttappa, also had social awareness as the central element of their writing. In my understanding, Karanth surpassed them. The writer Devanoor Mahadeva is also a leading activist in Karnataka, a person chasing the difficult contours of the question of equality with intensity. All of them have given Kannada literature its progressive character.

Bengali writer Mahashweta Devi came to be intimately related with my life as an Adivasi rights activist. In the early 1980s, I had launched *Setu*, a journal of literary translations, and was keen to have a Mahashweta Devi story for it. Her own translations of *Death of Jagmohan*, *The Elephant* and *Seeds* appeared in *Setu*. The manuscripts looked uninviting: typed in the smallest possible font size on sheets smudged with blue carbon. Yet, their realism and political analysis made them great stories. I knew that she had written about the kind of India that was mine too. In the mid-'90s, I decided to invite her to Baroda for a lecture on the Denotified Tribes. The Jnanpith and Magsaysay awards given to her in 1996-1997 made things a bit difficult. Nevertheless, she accepted my invitation. She spoke at length about the Adivasi struggle at Palamau, about her adventures collecting material on Laxmibai of Jhansi, and how she lost the Jnanpith award cheque given to her by Nelson Mandela. Her lecture was deeply moving. She spoke of the civilisational graces of the Adivasis, of how our society has mindlessly destroyed their culture, and how innocent persons are brutalised. She described the context in which the infamous Criminal Tribes Act, 1871, was introduced, the process of denotification in 1952 and the plight of the nomadic communities in India ever since. She then narrated the gruesome episode of the custodial death of Budhan Sabar in Purulia. The next day, in Baroda, we formed the Denotified and Nomadic Tribes Rights Action Group, the DNT-RAG. We travelled the length and breadth of India in quest of knowing the lives and stories of the Denotified and Nomadic Tribes, communities that had been wrongly branded during the colonial times as 'criminal tribes.' We continued our campaign for many years till the central government appointed a National DNT Commission.

Between visits to Delhi and travels in Maharashtra, she made frequent trips to Gujarat. Baroda became her second home, Tejgadh her sacred grove for communion with the Adivasis. "In Tejgadh alone," she said, "my bones will find rest. Ganesh, you will understand, I am tired, of it all, this praise, and this deification. I hate it."

I often wondered about the source of Mahashweta's strength, the literary influences that shaped her powerful style, the political philosophies that contributed to the making of her ideology. She never confessed to having influences, except that of the film-maker Ritwik Ghatak, her uncle. I am amazed how someone like her, slated to be a middle-class housewife, had managed to transcend so many prisons to become what she was—a writer with a frightening economy of words.

These very few writers I have mentioned stand out in the literary history of India since Independence. However, these are but a few and have their peers in other languages, who are equally worthy of being mentioned. Had there been space enough, I would have done that. ■